

Does ChatGPT have much more of an environmental impact than other large tech companies?

Posted by u/MizGinger • 0 points • 5 comments

I'm seeing the "don't use AI" because of its environmental impact take all over social media. Is there definitive info that shows that GPT has more impact than say, TikTok, Amazon, Meta, etc?

I feel like I'm seeing the argument everywhere lately and I don't don't know if that's just because it's getting traction on social media, or there was a study or something that I missed.

Comments

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-06-04 21:35 UTC

[removed]

u/Strange-Term-4168 • 1 points • 2025-04-22 02:24 UTC

No and relative to everything else, tech energy consumption is such a negligible issue it's insane people try to make it one. Yea when a billion people search something, it uses up a lot of energy/carbon/water/whatever the hell you want to complain about, but compare that to those billion people just driving their car half an hour to get starbucks or some other crap from the store. All of the chatgpt searches you do in your life will never even add up to one hour of driving your car.

u/TheMagicalLawnGnome • 4 points • 2025-04-21 15:38 UTC

This is selective outrage.

AI has an undeniable environmental impact, I'm not disputing that.

But so do things like chocolate bars, and coffee. So do cell phones and laptops. So does Amazon, and social media. Even just eating nuts is environmentally irresponsible.

Many of the same people critiquing AI also own American-sized cars, and live in single family homes. They eat meat. They drink almond milk, eat chocolate, and snack on hamburgers.

Anyone living as a part of contemporary American/European society has a massive carbon/ water footprint.

So when someone is criticizing AI, what they're doing is using environmental concerns to justify a critique that they already wanted to make, without applying that same critique to anything else they do.

Just think about it: all those people making this critique are literally doing so from a cell phone/computer, on the internet.

And here's the thing - it's not just about how much energy is used - it's about the purpose it's being used for.

AI is an extremely productive tool. It can solve real problems, make real contributions in science and business.

Meanwhile, TikTok...spreads propaganda and misinformation? Let people film memes?

Like, if we're going to start critiquing things that waste energy/resources, social media is going to be first on the list, as there is literally no redeeming value to it.

Which, to be clear, I'm not saying we should prohibit social media for environmental reasons. But what I am saying is that anyone making some sort of environmentally-based objection to AI on TikTok is an absolute hypocrite who shouldn't be taken seriously.

My personal take is that AI is energy intensive, but offers significant productive potential in key areas of science and industry, and thus requires us to focus on ensuring a steady supply of low-carbon, water-efficient infrastructure.

That's how you constructively engage with the issue; not ill informed, hypocritical Instagram posts.

u/kikipitchingdelivery • 1 points • 2025-06-23 22:05 UTC

People use AI to spread misinformation and trash content on social media too.

u/Lonely_Cupcake1727 • 1 points • 2025-06-04 21:11 UTC

So sorry to nitpick, but almond milk actually still uses less water than dairy milk (though it does use more than other nondairy milks); I completely agree with your point though and you worded it perfectly!

u/TheMagicalLawnGnome • 1 points • 2025-06-05 16:15 UTC

Good to know. I just know almond farming in general is an incredibly water-intensive activity, and one that is for a product that is entirely optional/unnecessary. I.e. we could all stop eating almonds, and nutritionally it would not matter, and the environmental benefits would be huge.

But people like almonds enough that they're willing to cause significant environmental impact because they... taste good.

Which, again, you could say the same stuff about a million other products, not trying to pick on almonds here.

As we agree, the broader point is that pretty much anyone in modern Western countries consumes an amount of resources that are literally impossible for earth to sustain if everyone had that level of wealth / access.

So while it's a fair discussion to talk about how to handle this situation, whenever people single out AI for its resource consumption, it conveniently ignores the vast amount of resources people waste in their daily lives on far less productive things.

To put it another way, chocolate bars don't have the potential to cure diseases and advance important research, but people happily devastate the ecosystem of West Africa to eat an entirely unnecessary / unhealthy treat. Meanwhile AI can add real value to the world, but everyone is up in arms about it.

u/JiveTurkey927 • 4 points • 2025-04-21 14:56 UTC

Most of the people complaining about AI power consumption are drinking Nestle bottled water, using batteries filled with Cobalt, or wearing or buying diamonds. I'm not saying they're necessarily wrong to be concerned with power usage, but it also feels like the outrage flavor of the month.

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-04-21 13:00 UTC

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u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-04-21 13:00 UTC

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